

**COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source**

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# **Exploring FOSS communities**

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# Housekeeping

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- Do we have notetakers for [today's topics](#)?
  - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
  - You should now be able to see start/target dates!
  - After submission, I will add a reviewer
- You should have all received an invitation to join as an "Outside Collaborator"

# Today's Goals

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- Look at the projects you shared for [homework](#):
  - Common documents
  - Project activity
  - Communication channels
- Understand the various roles in FOSS communities

*I will use [Inkscape](#) and [QBittorrent](#) as examples. Please pick 1-2 others to look at and answer questions during this class.*

# Common (non-code) Documents

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While there are no real "rules" to open source, most repos will contain:

- README
- LICENSE
- CONTRIBUTING
- INSTALL
- Maybe AGENTS, CODE\_OF\_CONDUCT, CODING\_STYLE, etc

*These are often in all-caps titled Markdown files, but neither is guaranteed*



*What common documents do you see? How do they differ?*

# Evaluating project activity

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- Issues (GitHub) or Work Items (GitLab) are "to do" items
- Pull/merge requests are accomplishing the "to dos"
- Consider:
  - Which items get closed and why
  - Which get lots of comments
  - Age of open items
  - Tags
- What are the official communication channels, and how often do people post?



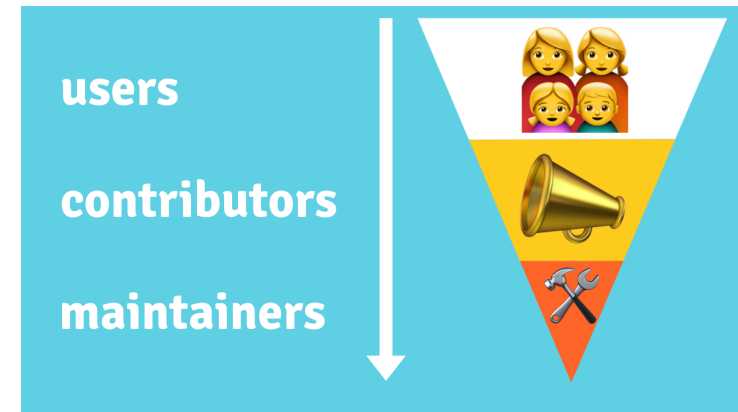
*How active are the projects?*

*What communication  
channels are most used?*

# Roles in FOSS projects

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- You are already a **user** — might submit bug report
- This semester, you will become a **contributor**:
  - Reproduce bugs
  - Write code, documentation, translations
  - Someone will review your submission
- **Maintainers** are the project leaders who review and merge PRs, manage releases, etc
- The **bus factor** in FOSS is often very low!





***What are the key roles? Who are the people in these roles?***

# Next up

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- Lab exercise: merging the PRs submitted last week
- Monday: special guest lecture on copyright and licensing
- [Homework question](#): read about licensing